

Wallet Security & Self-Custody Checklist

A one-page reference for beginners taking custody of their keys

- Choose a Hardware Wallet:**
 - Choose the tradeoff you can maintain: a card wallet is simple, USB is familiar, and an air-gapped device minimizes wireless exposure.
 - Buy only from the manufacturer or its authorized store — never a marketplace listing or a seller who sends a pre-initialized device.
 - Check the seal, device authenticity, and official firmware during setup; initialize it yourself and reject unexpected recovery words.
- Back Up the Seed Phrase:**
 - Generate the recovery phrase on the hardware wallet — never in a phone app, browser, or pre-printed package.
 - Write every word in the exact order on paper or a durable metal backup; never photograph, type, or upload it.
 - Keep two physically separate backups protected from fire, water, theft, and casual household access.
- Avoid Phishing:**
 - Bookmark the manufacturer, wallet app, and exchange websites; do not trust sponsored search results or unsolicited support messages.
 - Read the full address and transaction details on the device screen before approving anything.
 - No legitimate support person needs your seed phrase, PIN, backup words, or remote access to your device.
- Set Up and Test Small:**
 - Update firmware from the official app, set a unique PIN, and record the wallet name and setup date without recording the seed.
 - Send a small test amount to the new address, then confirm receipt and a small test send before moving more.
 - Practice restoring the wallet on a spare device where supported; document the steps and keep that guide separate from the seed.
- Protect Access and Recovery:**
 - Enable an authenticator app or hardware-key 2FA on every exchange account; prefer it over SMS where possible.
 - Store exchange backup codes offline and separately from the wallet seed phrase.
 - Review the recovery plan with a trusted person and rehearse it once a year or after a major device change.

Print this page before moving meaningful funds to self-custody. Work through every unchecked line, keep the recovery material offline, and rehearse the recovery plan before you need it.